# SCRIPT TITLE

Written by

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FADE IN:

EXT. RED HALLOW HOUSE - EARLY EVENING

An old HUNTING LODGE looms in the tangled California forest. Wind slices through overgrown brush. A rusted GATE blocks the gravel drive, a faded “NO TRESPASSING” sign flapping against iron bars.

A BLACK CROW perches silently on the gatepost, watching.

EXT. RURAL ROAD OUTSIDE GATE - CONTINUOUS

A black rental SUV grinds to a stop along the shoulder.

BILLY CRUZ (29) climbs out—hoodie half-zipped over a worn paranormal YouTube tee, long hair tied back under a black bandana. Scruffy. Unimpressed.

He yanks at the gate’s lock—rusted shut. It doesn’t move. A jagged edge SLICES his palm. Blood drops.

SLOW MOTION: A single drop hits the dirt—and VANISHES. No trace. The crow croaks once.

Billy rips the bandana from his head and wraps his hand.

BILLY
(grimacing)
Nothing says horror stream like tetanus.

He shoulders his heavy gear bag and starts the long walk. The crow tracks him with unblinking eyes.

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - VERANDA - MOMENTS LATER

Billy unlocks the boarded front door. It CREAKS open. He pauses. One breath. One beat. Tightens the bloody wrap on his hand. Steps inside.

INT. FOYER - REALITY - NIGHT

A cold blast of stale air. Shadows stretch and hesitate.

Billy flicks on his HEADLAMP—his VLOG CAMERA rig sits just above the lens.

The door CREAKS closed behind him.

BILLY
(to camera)
Haunted homies—Billy Cruz. Today's gig: Red Hallow.
(beat)
Three stories of rot, mold, and bad vibes. Rigging solo for Wesley's livestream, but you get the director's cut.

He walks deeper into the black.

BILLY (CONT'D)
(to camera)
If I scream halfway through—clip it.

CAMERA POV —

MONTAGE - BILLY SETS THE STAGE

- TWO MINI GENERATORS hum to life: one out back, one in the wine cellar.

BILLY (V.O.)
Should keep the scares humming 'til sunrise.

- Wires threaded through banisters. EMF meters blink red. LED strips flicker, programmed to lightning.

- FOG MACHINES exhale mist across the upper landing.

- SPEAKERS vanish beneath antique furniture.

BILLY (V.O.)
Showbiz, baby.

- He fits a BLACKMAGIC SWITCHER into his pack. Syncs camera feeds to trip sensors.

- Boots a TERADEK ENCODER to a SAT UPLINK.

CLOSE ON - RUGGED IPAD UI

A jet-black touchscreen pulses: toggles, feed windows, diagnostics.

He swipes through: RIG 1 - CHAIR DROP, RIG 2 - FOYER PULL, FX: VENT MIST, CAMERA ARRAY, ROOM MIC GRID, SAT UPLINK - 8.3 Mbps, REDUNDANT STREAM, FAILSAFE OVERRIDE. At the bottom: a pulsing icon—"GO LIVE."

He taps it.

A low HUM. Lights stir to life—off-color, wrong somehow.

Billy checks his SAT PHONE—one bar.

BILLY (V.O.)
Dead zone. As advertised.
(beat)
Cameras one... two... attic's glitchy. Good enough.

TEXTING:

BILLY (TEXT)
"Wes—house rigged and live. Creepiest fuckin' gig yet. Gonna scare the shit outta those kids. Main gate's rusted shut. Enjoy the hike."

SEND.

He zips his pack. One last check. Heads toward the front door. Lights flicker—dimmer now.

BILLY (CONT'D)
(to camera)
Alright crew—out of here. If I die, tell my 200 subs I went out faking hauntings for dudes with merch lines.

Then— a sharp DROP in temperature. A high-frequency WHINE bleeds from the walls. Billy halts. Reaches for the knob—

DISTANT SCREAM upstairs.

BLACKOUT. All power dead. Silence.

Billy freezes. Slowly raises his headlamp. Across the wallpaper, a BLACK INK STAIN spreads outward like veins. Atramentus has tasted blood.

His headlamp sputters out.

A metallic SNAP. A dry, ragged inhale. A visceral CRUNCH, too close. The sound of something heavy being dragged across the floor.

Then silence.

SMASH TO BLACK:

TITLE CARD: SESSION ZERO

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - NIGHT

Headlights slice through the mist as a sleek black AUDI SUV crawls down the overgrown dirt road.

CUT TO:

INT. AUDI SUV - NIGHT

WESLEY CRAVEN WISE (27) rides shotgun. Curated chaos and too-good lighting, every grin engineered for reaction clips. Tossed hair. Designer jacket. Minimalist tee that screams "casual, but rich."

A mounted vlogging cam records him. He flips on the influencer smile, but for a split second—behind the eyes—exhaustion and raw panic leak through. Debt, fear, desperation. He buries it with another grin.

WESLEY
(to camera)
What's up, weirdos. Tonight's the one. Red Hallow.
Condemned. Cursed.
(leans in)
Thirteen years ago, the Millers were butchered while on vacation in this lodge.
No suspects. No answers.
(beat)
And tonight, September thirteenth, we're bringing you something new.
D&D in a fucking murder house.
(beat)
So hit that like button, drop your bets in chat, and let's roll.

He swings the camera toward the foggy road.

WESLEY (V.O.)
Welcome to Red Hallow.
(with flair)
Welcome to Session Zero.

Driving, KELLY SHEAR (23). Layered thrift-store comfort and quiet defiance. Pale. Watchful. Glitching SAT PHONE in her lap. Her eyes stay on the screen—but track everything.

KELLY
Nav's dead. No signal. Even satellite's choking.

WESLEY
Billy warned me. Said it’s the creepiest place he’s ever rigged.

KELLY
(surprised)
He… rigs the houses ahead of time?

Wesley grins at her reaction, a little smug.

WESLEY
Yeah. Guy’s my secret sauce. Whole setup’s turnkey. Cameras, fog, jump scares, you name it.

Kelly hides a flicker of unease. She didn’t know. She stares back at the dead SAT feed, quieter now.

The fog thickens. The SUV creeps forward.

EXT. AUDI SUV - CONTINUOUS

They reach the iron gate—once rusted shut.

Now, WIDE OPEN.

WESLEY
Guess he got the gate.

They pass Billy’s SUV, abandoned in the fog. Neither reacts. Oblivious.

The lodge emerges. Three stories of skeletal rot, vines clinging like veins. Veranda lights choke and flicker.

Wesley leans out the window, vlogging. Kelly grips the wheel tighter.

EXT. AUDI SUV - FRONT DRIVE - MOMENTS LATER

They park. Cold air presses in.

KELLY
(low)
It’s colder now.

WESLEY
(mocking)
Goosebumps?

CLOSE ON: The fine hair on her arm, rising.

Mist curls across the windshield, as a faint BREATH fogs the inside glass. Not theirs.

Wesley clocks something in Kelly's hand.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
You brought your spirit guide?

Kelly opens her palm—an OLD POCKET WATCH. Fractured. Ticking.

KELLY
He always follows.

TICK. TICK. 9:13.

Wesley smirks, but it's brittle.

WESLEY
Your ghost story, huh?

KELLY
I've told you what I can.
(beat, quiet)
Not everything.

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - NIGHT

Fog curls around the veranda like a living thing. Headlights vanish into mist. Wesley and Kelly climb out, each carrying a gear bag.

A BLACK CROW perches on the railing. Still. Watching. Its eyes glint red.

Wesley flips the flashlight beneath his chin, grinning for the camera.

WESLEY
(to camera)
You saw us prank those frat bros in the haunted hospital, tonight's bigger. Three players. A Dungeon Master with no mercy. And me—your fearless MC.
(grinning)
Plus, a special guest, ghost hunter, tech whisperer, and full-time spirit creeper, Kelly Shear.

He pans the camera to her. Kelly smirks, but it never reaches her eyes.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
(to camera)
Maybe she'll even sit in on the game.

Kelly pauses. Her breath is visible. A WHISPER rides the wind. She looks up—

A SHADOW shifts behind a cracked second, floor window. Still. Watching.

Her hand tightens on her coat.

The veranda lights flicker. The front door GROANS open—on its own.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
(to camera)
Let's go talk to some spirits.

They move toward the house. Kelly lingers, eyes on the upstairs window, grip tightening on the watch.

CUT TO:

INT. JEEP CHEROKEE - HIGHWAY 56 - LATER

An OLD JEEP winds through dense fog, headlights brushing gnarled trees. Inside—warmth, friendship, nerves disguised as sarcasm.

MAVERICK THOMAS (18),backwards cap, drives. Swagger that fills the room and frays at the seams.

HOLLY STANTON (18), eyeliner and combat boots, leans into the passenger door. Warm. Eyes shadowed by something she can't shake.

In the back, LUCAS BOSSE (17), hoodie high, fidgets with his bag strap. An artist's stillness masking something unsettled.

-and JAXTON WILLIS (17), messy haired, D&D binder in his lap, stares ahead. A smile that hides something frayed at the edges.

His phone BUZZES: LUCY CALLING.

He silences it. The others notice.

HOLLY
Not picking up?

JAXTON
We argued. She’s pissed I came here tonight.

LUCAS
Anniversary?

Jaxton nods once. The weight drops. They all know.

HOLLY
You don’t have to say it. We know what today is.

MAVERICK
(gentler now)
Lucy just wants you with her. Like she’s always had to be with you.

Jaxton says nothing. Stares ahead, guilt creeping in. The phone buzzes again. He kills the screen.

LUCAS
Ten bucks says this place reeks like mold and expired weed.

MAVERICK
Wrong. It’ll smell like Jaxton after a six-hour boss fight.

JAXTON
I showered. That’s emotional sweat you remember.

HOLLY
Because you traumatize us. Sentient pumpkins? Ooze orgies?

LUCAS
I still have nightmares about that cube.

JAXTON
You married it.

LUCAS
It was charming.

MAVERICK
Just your type.

They laugh. The tension eases, but the shadow of the day lingers.

HOLLY
I'm gonna miss this. Even your meta-gaming, Jaxton.

LUCAS
Should've brought a cake.

JAXTON
Settle for no mid-battle tears.

LUCAS
That's a gamble.
(beat)
Sophomore year, when I kept disappearing. You all waited. No one asked. Just... waited.

HOLLY
You were our bard, Lucas.

MAVERICK
Also the reason I drink hibiscus tea and know Bowie's B-sides.

Lucas smiles at Maverick. Brief. Loaded.

HOLLY
I still remember our first game. Jaxton barely spoke, unless it was in character.

JAXTON
I was calculating exits.

MAVERICK
Because we're intimidatingly hot.

HOLLY
Because we cared.
(beat)
You were this quiet storm. And I knew, day one... you'd be the best DM I ever had.

JAXTON
Still the best arcs.

They crest the hill. Red Hallow looms.

LUCAS
Jesus.

HOLLY
Wesley’s probably crouched behind a bush with a GoPro and fake blood.

MAVERICK
His streams are 60% effects, 30% acting, 10% trauma porn.

JAXTON
What if tonight’s real? They say it’s actually haunted.

MAVERICK
Then I’ll die dramatically and haunt this Jeep.

HOLLY
Not before helping me move to New York.

MAVERICK
You just want me to carry boxes.

HOLLY
Obviously.

LUCAS
Graduating still feels fake.

MAVERICK
Vermont gave me a full ride. Parents were ready with a boot.

HOLLY
Art school’s been the plan, but... now that it’s here—

Silence. They sit with it.

JAXTON
I’m not going anywhere.
(beat)
Lucy needs me. And today... today’s hard enough without me bailing.

The others nod, quiet solidarity. They’ve carried this grief with him before.

Jaxton brushes a finger over a bright green mini.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
You always packed the goblin dwarf, even after I stopped using him.

MAVERICK
That neon-bearded goblin? Iconic.

HOLLY
Looked like it bathed in toxic waste.

JAXTON
Dad printed it. Slicer glitched. Mom laughed ‘til she cried. One of the last times we all did.

The car goes quiet. Memory breathing between them.

LUCAS
You’ve got us, Jax.

HOLLY
We’re not gone yet.

JAXTON
You’re my family now.

HOLLY
Always.

They ride. Silence, earned.

MAVERICK
We’ll be okay. Even apart.

LUCAS
Promise?

MAVERICK
Promise.

HOLLY
Write. Not just memes.

JAXTON
Only memes. Deep, soulful ones.

They turn off the highway and crest the final rise. The lodge stands, rotting, skeletal, watching.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
Can’t believe we actually have permission to stream here.
(beat)
We do have permission, right?

MAVERICK
Too late. I'm ready to punch a ghost.

HOLLY
This is for you, Jax.

They fall quiet.

LUCAS
Let's make tonight count.

HEADLIGHTS sweep past a MASSIVE BLACK CROW. Its red eyes glow. It doesn't flinch.

The Jeep slows.

CUT TO:

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - FRONT DRIVE - NIGHT

The JEEP rolls to a stop. Gravel crunches beneath the tires. Fog coils around the wheels like breath.

The LODGE looms ahead, crooked, massive, waiting.

A beat of silence inside the Jeep.

LUCAS
Okay. Deep breaths. We're doing this.

MAVERICK
(sarcastic)
Yup. Totally normal Friday night. Drive to a murder scene, unpack emotional trauma, roll initiative. At least we're going out strong, beers and mushrooms.

HOLLY
(pulling a flask)
And if anyone grows a spine, a real drink.

Lucas, impressed.

LUCAS
Underprepared.

JAXTON
You usually are.

Maverick squints at the lodge. Behind a cracked second-story window, a SILHOUETTE. Still. Watching.

He blinks. It’s gone.

MAVERICK
(to himself)
Creepy.

HOLLY
You see something?

MAVERICK
Just the house flexing.

HOLLY
(grabbing her bag)
For Jaxton. One last story.

They climb out. Begin unloading: gaming gear, LED flashlights, a 12-pack of beer.

The air’s colder than it should be. Lucas shivers and adjusts his hoodie.

LUCAS
(to Jaxton)
Got the minis?

JAXTON
(tapping his case)
Always.

Jaxton’s phone BUZZES again, LUCY. He silences it quickly. The others glance at him. They know.

A beat. Shared silence.

Jaxton looks at them, guilt flickering, then forces a grin.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
If this is our last quest, we’re going out rolling nat 20s.

Lucas grins, follows him up the steps. Maverick and Holly hang back.

LUCAS
This place has main character death energy.

JAXTON
It’s perfect.

They share a quiet smile.

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - VERANDA - SAME TIME

Maverick and Holly linger below the steps.

HOLLY
You okay?

MAVERICK
Just feeling off.

HOLLY
That’s just the asbestos.

She nudges him. No smile back.

MAVERICK
(low)
Before we go in...

HOLLY
Yeah?

MAVERICK
You need to tell Jax how you feel.

HOLLY
(stiffens)
What?

MAVERICK
Don’t pretend. You’ve crushed on him since day one. Fence climb check.

HOLLY
I fell three times.

MAVERICK
And he still made you the hero. That’s love, right?

HOLLY
Doesn’t matter. He’s staying. I’m not.

MAVERICK
Exactly why you have to tell him.

A beat.

MAVERICK (CONT'D)
You only get this kind of connection once.

She stares at him.

HOLLY
What about you?

MAVERICK
(small smile)
I'm full of secrets. But tonight's not mine.

They head up the steps, joining Jaxton and Lucas. The four stand together. A quiet moment.

CUT TO:

INT. FOYER - REALITY - NIGHT

The front door GROANS open. The group steps into the dark.

Air thick. Damp. Heavy. Mold, rot, and something faintly metallic cling to the walls. The staircase climbing upward like a broken spine.

WESLEY is already inside, adjusting his shoulder rig, checking angles. KELLY moves methodically behind him, calibrating mics. She lingers on every shadow like it's alive.

JAXTON
(grinning)
Dude. Wesley Wise. In the flesh.

WESLEY
Top mod Jaxton, right? Appreciate you pulling this crew together.

JAXTON
Appreciate the invite. This place is insane.

LUCAS
(eyeing the gear)
You're really streaming this?

WESLEY
All of it. D&D. Real time. In a murder house. No filters. No take-backs.

HOLLY
(sweeping her light)
You didn’t say it was full on Blair Witch.

JAXTON
You said you were bored.

HOLLY
Yeah. I pictured gym mats and bad pizza. Not haunted insulation.

Kelly adjusts a gain dial, monotone.

KELLY
It’s mostly structurally sound.

Awkward glances. The kids exchange looks, unsure who she is.

HOLLY
(to Wesley, nodding toward Kelly)
And she is...?

WESLEY
Kelly. First gig with me. Ghost hunter. Extra clicks for the stream.

KELLY
(flat)
I’m here to listen.

LUCAS
(to Jaxton, low)
She’s got the same vibe as the house.

JAXTON
Not by accident.

Maverick pulls out a foil-wrapped mushroom chocolate bar.

MAVERICK
Druidic offering before the ritual?

LUCAS
Like the old sessions. Nostalgic chaos.

They each take a piece.

HOLLY
(to Kelly)
You want one, ghost whisperer?

KELLY
(shaking her head)
No need.

Jaxton moves to the parlor, begins unpacking terrain and dice.

JAXTON
I'll set up here. You guys should explore.

WESLEY
Yeah, get the vibe. Ghost tour before initiative.

HOLLY
Let me know when I need to seduce something incorporeal.

MAVERICK
If I die before round one, I'm haunting your dorm.

LUCAS
(to Kelly)
Anything yet? Ectoplasmic mildew?

Kelly studies the wallpaper. A faint black stain pulses outward, Atramentus has tasted blood, then vanishes. Her watch ticks once. 9:13.

KELLY
(quiet)
The house is already listening.

The others move, flashlights sweeping across cracked wallpaper, warped wood.

The house exhales. Watching. Waiting.

CUT TO:

INT. VARIOUS ROOMS - REALITY - TOUR MONTAGE

WESLEY (V.O.)
Welcome to "Nerds in the Wild" — haunted edition. Watch our brave party wander deeper into regret.
(beat)
(MORE)

WESLEY (V.O.) (CONT'D)
We rigged enough jump scares to make them question every life choice.

- Holly opens a dusty music box in a child's bedroom. The broken ballerina spins once, A BLAST OF COLD AIR shoots from a hidden vent. She recoils, shrieking.

HOLLY
Swear to god—next next one of these hits me, I'm walking.

- Lucas traces oil paintings in the hallway. One shows a smiling family. As he brushes another, a DISTORTED WHISPER hisses from a speaker above.

LUCAS
Cool. Haunted house ASMR.

- Maverick opens a pantry door. Inside: rotting food arranged on overturned plates like a dinner party. A silver spoon glints in mold. He gags.

MAVERICK
Nasty.

He turns to leave, stops. On the floor, a SAT PHONE. Cracked. Blood smeared.

MAVERICK (CONT'D)
(to himself)
Knew they faked their streams.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - MOMENTS LATER

The group regathers. Maverick tosses the phone to Wesley.

MAVERICK
This yours? Found it near the pantry. Nice touch with the blood.

Wesley, caught off-guard, covers with a grin.

WESLEY
Must've dropped it on walkthrough.

He tries to turn it on. Dead. Hands it to Kelly.

KELLY
(low)
That's blood. Real.

WESLEY
Billy’s a pro. Said he’d check in tomorrow. We’ll deal with it then.

LUCAS
If this place had a therapist, they fumbled their roll.

Jaxton flattens the game map on the table. His hands steady, too steady.

A POLAROID slides free from his notes: JAXTON + LUCY, age 10, flashlight campfire. On the white border, a scribble, “REMEMBER.”

He palms it back into the notebook.

JAXTON
Then it's working. The immersion. Atmosphere. You're unsettled. You're inside the world now.

KELLY
(without looking up)
Not everything here is make-believe.

Everyone glances at her. She keeps wiring mics, calm but cold.

WESLEY
(chiming in)
We did that asylum shoot last year, same vibe. Gear glitched, shadows moved, half the chat thought we faked it.
(beat)
We didn't.

Maverick smiles, doubt on his face.

KELLY
You don’t need to live somewhere to connect with what’s soaked in.
(beat)
Some places remember better than people do.

HOLLY
Remember what?

KELLY
Regret. Trauma. Things that never ended right.

MAVERICK
(to Wesley)
Okay, is that like, part of the bit?

WESLEY
Roll her in, DM. She’s already NPC-ing the house.
(to camera)
Drop a comment if Kelly’s already the scariest thing in here.

LIVESTREAM CHAT LIGHTS UP:

**”KELLY IS POSSESSED???”**

**"she's not acting. i'm calling it."**

**”this isn't scripted. no way.”**

Jaxton spreads dice and minis.

JAXTON
She’s in. We roll in five.

The players settle into their seats. The table glows under the chandelier's faint, buzzing light. The mood shifts, nervous energy giving way to something looser.

Holly unzips her bag and pulls out a silver flask.

HOLLY
Don’t ask what’s in it. Just know it'll make you braver.

She unscrews the cap and takes a sip. Passes it to Jaxton.

JAXTON
To one last story.

MAVERICK
The official potion of courage.

LUCAS
Just mushrooms tonight. Back on meds.

WESLEY
(to camera)
For legal reasons, this is all soda.

Holly raises her flask. Everyone lifts their drink, cans, bottles, imaginary goblets.

HOLLY
To chaos. To summer. To stories that end better than they started.

They clink. The ritual begins. Kelly slides into the fifth chair without a word.

There are SIX chairs.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
Wait. If she's playing should be five, right?

JAXTON
Yeah. I—I guess.

LUCAS
Okay. I'm not sitting in that one.

MAVERICK
What if it rolls better than you?

Nervous laughter.

JAXTON'S POV: The stream glitches. For a moment, an old-school Game Master screen flickers onscreen, then vanishes.

LOWER-THIRD: "Start a story. Reveal the wound. Pay the cost. Only then can you end it." It disappears before anyone else notices. - END POV.

The chandelier SWAYS. No wind.

Jaxton finishes arranging the dice and miniatures.

JAXTON
Alright, party. For the viewers and for each other, name, class, race, and a little flavor. Let's meet the heroes.

MAVERICK
(booming, mock-theatrical)
Korgoth Stormjaw, half-orc barbarian. Raised by wolves. Punches gods for fun. Loves puppies.

HOLLY
(grinning)
Syla Veilshade. Drow rogue. Escaped the Underdark with nothing but sass and a poison kit.

LUCAS
(clearing throat)
Elowyn Lightfoot, halfling bard. Former tavern singer turned reluctant hero. Special move, seduction and scream ballads.

JAXTON
(nodding)
I'll be guiding the journey. You'll meet my NPCs and monsters along the way.
(to Kelly)
You?

KELLY
(flat)
I'm a witch. My familiar's a spirit with a long memory and bad manners.

WESLEY
(to camera)
Not ten minutes in and she’s already breaking the fourth wall.

JAXTON
Here we go, lets see where you all start tonight.

Jaxton rolls a D20. It bounces once, spinning far longer than it should. Too long.

WESLEY
(to camera)
Is that... normal?

The twenty-sided die settles. THIRTEEN.

The camera feed on Wesley's shoulder rig flickers.

In one frame, a flash of static, there's someone SITTING IN THE SIXTH CHAIR. Then it's empty again. NO ONE NOTICED.

The chandelier above JERKS TO A STOP.

JAXTON
You stand in a quiet clearing. Moonlight cuts through twisted trees. You feel... observed.

Flashlights cast long shadows. Nervous laughter from around the table.

MAVERICK
I ready my great axe!

JAXTON
A distant howl breaks the silence.

LOUD CREAK. SOMETHING sits at the sixth chair. Blurred. Still.

LUCAS
Tell me someone else saw that.

The lights shimmer unnaturally—

BLACKOUT.

Kelly’s pocket watch TICKS. BACKWARD.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - MOMENTS LATER

The power SNAPS back. Flashing, everyone's face in brief strobing glimpses. FEAR.

Jaxton checks the dice tray. The D20 SPLIT OPEN. Bone dust scattered.

JAXTON
(confused, to himself)
This isn't part of the campaign.

Beat- He examines the split D20 behind the DM screen, and looks towards the others, not knowing what to say.

Wesley rewinds his rig. Zooms. In a still frame, the sixth chair, OCCUPIED. A BOY. Blurred. Mouth open. Hollow.

Wesley leans in, speechless.

KELLY
It’s how it comes through.

The game map has CHANGED. New rooms. A tower. A script rewritten in bleeding ink.

JAXTON
(reading)
“Wherever the story finds a wound... it grows.”

A LOUD THUMP echoes through the house. The stairs, pitch black. Kelly’s watch TICKS again.

A DOOR CREAKS OPEN upstairs. HEAVY FOOTSTEPS. Silence presses.

WESLEY
(to camera)
And that’s our first official unexplained noise. Timestamp it.
(grinning)
Paranormal points if you caught the ghost kid in the chair.

LIVESTREAM CHAT EXPLODES:

**“SIX shadows. Count them.”**

**"Whose kid is that???"**

**“Bro broke a cursed die.”**

**“I think the game’s playing YOU.”**

HOLLY
(to the group)
Please tell me that's Wesley's audio loop.

LUCAS
(working to impress Holly)
It's probably nothing. House settling. Pipes. I'll check it out.

Everyone stares at him.

HOLLY
We just got the crap scared out of us and your move is split the party and "Scooby-Doo" it?

LUCAS
I’ll scream if I get eaten.

HOLLY
Lucas—

He heads toward the stairs. Flashlight cutting through the dark.

CUT TO:

INT. STAIRCASE - REALITY - CONTINUOUS

Lucas ascends. Each step CREAKS like a warning. The walls tighten around him, close, suffocating. His flashlight shakes in his hand.

LUCAS
(soft, to himself)
Okay, just an old house.

Closed doors line the hallway. Peeling wallpaper. Warped mirrors. Dust coated portraits. At the end, one door ajar.

He walks toward it.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

Wesley in full host mode, shoulder rig aimed like a spotlight.

WESLEY
(to camera)
Alright, weirdos, our Bard Lucas is entering unknown territory. If he dies, it's because he didn't roll a D20.
(holding up a D20 die)
And let the Dungeon Master know he was going to use his characters perception skill to check if there is a monster upstairs.

THE LIVESTREAM CHAT ERUPTS:

**"WHO TF IS THAT ON THE STAIRS?"**

**"Behind him—a monster. BEHIND HIM."**

**"Rewind. Timestamp 41:07."**

**"Yo that's not one of the players."**

Kelly freezes. Her eyes narrow. She leans in, fingers brushing the edge of the monitor like she's trying to connect with the houses energy.

KELLY
(low)
Something’s already here. Watching him.

Wesley scrubs the feed back. Pauses. Onscreen: Lucas on the stairs.

Behind him, a FIGURE. Too tall. Too still. Distorted, vibrating. Limbs limp, wrong. A smear of humanoid shadow. A tendril of dark smoke rises in reverse, slithering toward Lucas's back.

KELLY (CONT'D)
(quiet)
It's a feeder.

CUT TO:

INT. ROOM - ALTERED REALITY

Lucas pushes the door open. Dim light. Air colder.

LUCAS
Time to prove ghosts aren't real.

He steps in. The DOOR SLAMS behind him. He spins—

No door. Just wall.

His flashlight dies.

Ahead, a narrow hallway, lined like a child's bedroom. Pastel wallpaper pulses faintly, like it's breathing. Each door labeled in a child's scrawl: "AGE 8." "AGE 9." "AGE 10." "AGE 11."

Lucas walks slowly, panic washes over him.

LUCAS (CONT'D)
This isn't real.

He tries the "AGE 8" door. LOCKED.

He passes "AGE 9." A soft laugh from behind the door, unmistakably a CHILDS VOICE.

Lucas freezes. Shakes. A hand reflexively goes to his medication bottle in his pocket.

His fingers tremble.

He reaches "AGE 10." The door CREAKS OPEN.

INT. AGE 10 ROOM - ALTERED REALITY

A perfect recreation of a summer day. Two bikes lie in the grass. A dirt path winds toward a nearby lake.

In the distance, two boys laugh, ten-year-old Lucas, and another boy, JONAH.

-suddenly, the scene STUTTERS, like an old VHS tape.

MEMORY FLASH: Water. Splashing. Gasping. Jonah SCREAMS. Lucas grabs his ears. Closes his eyes.

He stumbles backwards out of the room. The door slams shut.

INT. HALLWAY - ALTERED REALITY

The “AGE 11” door yawns open. Darkness inside. He’s pulled in.

INT. AGE 11 ROOM - ALTERED REALITY

A flooded basement. Water at his ankles. Flashlight flickers. In the center, a CHILD-SIZED BODY BAG.

He approaches.

JONAH (O.S.)
It was your idea.

Lucas stares.

LUCAS
I didn’t know... I was just a kid...

The bag TWITCHES. Lucas RUNS.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

The group sits, tension thick. The monitor is frozen, the distorted figure still visible.

JAXTON
Okay, it's just the mushrooms. We breathe. We play. That's the deal.

HOLLY
(to Kelly)
What’s a feeder?

Kelly stares at the static.

KELLY
Parasitic demon. I’ve seen sketches, Rookwell Archive. Mercer case.
(beat)
It doesn’t haunt places. It clings to people. Burrows into fear.

MAVERICK
We just started and you’re already dropping demon lore? Solid.
(to camera)
Y’all buying this?

LIVE STREAM CHAT EXPLODES:

**"Kelly is NOT acting."**

**"Lucas isn’t in frame anymore."**

**"This is real."**

HOLLY
He’s been gone too long.

Jaxton’s mask slips. He tries to stay in control.

JAXTON
We check if he’s not back in five. Let’s keep moving.

He flips his notes. Breathing steady.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
You stand at the edge of a dense forest. A howl echoes in the dark.

They settle, but tension bristles. A faint glow lights up words carved into the table: “Start a story. Reveal the wound. Pay the cost. Only then can you end it.”

KELLY
(quiet, shaken)
I’ve seen this before... the rules are always the same.

They glance at her.

KELLY (CONT'D)
This spirit wants a story it hasn't heard.

The lights buzz again. The dice rest still.

HOLLY
Then let's give it one worth remembering.

CUT TO:

INT. HALLWAY - ALTERED REALITY

Lucas crashes into a full-length mirror. He steadies himself, panting. His reflection stares back, ten years old. The boy raises a finger, pointing behind him.

Lucas turns.

JONAH, soaking wet and expressionless, stands inches away.

JONAH
Why didn't you help me?

The hallway COLLAPSES like a folding map.

INT. HALLWAY - REALITY - CONTINUOUS

Lucas lies on the floor, drenched in sweat. The door before him wide open. Pills scatter from a bottle beside him. Panicked, he scoops them up. The door SLAMS shut.

He runs, pauses at the stairs. A SHADOW BLUR crosses behind him. Fast. Wrong.

Lucas gasps, slips, and CRASHES down the stairs.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - CONTINUOUS

The group rushes in, flashlights jittering.

HOLLY
Lucas!

JAXTON
You okay?

Lucas groans, sits up with effort.

LUCAS
I... I slipped.

Maverick and Jaxton help Lucas to his feet, quick, concerned, hands on his arms. He's pale and unsteady but upright.

They cross back to the table slowly.

HOLLY
(soft)
Please sit.

Lucas settles into his seat. His eyes drifting.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
(relieved)
There he is.

LUCAS
(quietly)
It wasn't empty upstairs.

Silence.

LUCAS (CONT'D)
(shaken)
Has to be the mushrooms... let's just play.

WESLEY
(to camera)
Back from the House of Emotional Doom, our Bard returns. First to maybe get ghost-tapped.

Jaxton, lingers over the map, his eyes scanning it again. It's wrong. Not just the writing. Something about it feels personal.

JAXTON
Alright. The party descends into the undercroft of a ruined chapel. The air is wet. Heavy. There's a pulpit made of... teeth and the name Syla Veilshade is crossed out in the stone?

He flips his notebook. Every line written in his handwriting, but not by him.

HOLLY
Wait, what did you just say?

JAXTON
Your character’s name. On the wall.

HOLLY
(quiet)
I never told you that.

JAXTON
Told me what?

HOLLY
When I was thirteen... grief counseling. I wouldn’t speak. They had me draw.
(beat)
I drew a wall. With names. Mine was scratched out.

Beat. Silence crashes, they all look at one another, uncomfortable.

JAXTON
It’s on the map. Same name. Same scratch.

HOLLY
Perfect... mushrooms, whiskey, and childhood trauma. Delightful.

A CHILD’S LULLABY HUMS from the walls. Haunting. Wordless.

LUCAS
(nervous)
Is that the house or the wifi?

KELLY
(low)
It’s looking for a way in.

MAVERICK
(to Kelly)
Really? We’re doing this all night? We know Wesley rigs this stuff.

Kelly glances at her cracked watch, the second hand TICKS BACKWARD.

WESLEY
Look at the table.

He tilts the camera. The MAP INK SHIFTS IN REAL TIME. A stain blooms. New text appears: “The story remembers what you forget.”

THE LIVESTREAM CHAT LIGHTS UP:

**"wait was that line there before?"**

**"this just stopped being funny."**

**"someone screen record this."**

They all stare. No one speaks.

The only sound is the soft TICK of Kelly's watch.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
(to camera)
After a haunted intermission, we continue. Bets on who dies first?

JAXTON
(resets)
The corridor opens into a massive crypt. Sarcophagus center. Hooded statues line the walls. Faceless

HOLLY
Ominous.

JAXTON
You hear breathing. No one's near.

MAVERICK
I roll perception.

He rolls a D20 die. TWENTY. A critical success.

MAVERICK (CONT'D)
Boom. Nat twenty, baby.

A few small laughs. The tension dips—just for a second.

JAXTON
One statue... points at you.

MAVERICK
Like it's about to give me a quest or attack the party?

JAXTON
You blink and it now holds a sword.

WESLEY
Timestamp that weirdos. Statue just moved and pulled a weapon.

A GROAN under the floorboards. Kelly stiffens.

LUCAS
What the hell was that?

KELLY
Malignant energy. Restless. Feeds on fear and regret.

All eyes shift to her.

WESLEY
The spirit you said is tied to your watch?

KELLY
No, the parasitic demon in this house. It's called a feeder.

JAXTON
Wait, so you're attached to a spirit in your watch?

MAVERICK
Yeah that tracks!

KELLY
He's not chained to me. He's chained to the watch. The watch finds someone, and he finds them...
(beat)
I've never told anyone this before.

She places the cracked watch on the table.

KELLY (CONT'D)
I call him Puck.

MAVERICK
What, like a fairy?

KELLY
He came to me after the school fire I survived when I was eight.

SMASH TO:

FLASHBACK - INT. ABANDONED ELEMENTARY SCHOOL - DAY

Eight-year-old KELLY SHEAR sits alone. Her hands clutch a pocket watch. Still ticking. She isn't hiding. She's waiting.

KELLY (V.O.)
The first time, I thought he was a dream. The last time... I knew better.

A flicker. A shape forms in the shadows.

KELLY
You don’t scare me anymore.

The air shimmers. The shape twitches.

KELLY (V.O.)
He didn’t come to hurt me. He came to trade.

She kneels. Offers a crayon drawing, a boy, “Thanatos.”

KELLY
He was my friend. You took him. You can take me too.

A voice from the watch.

PUCK (O.S.)
You were never the offer. You were the door. You’re the witness.

The shape steps forward, TEETH MADE OF TIME. Kelly’s eyes go wide—

SMASH BACK TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

The group sit silent, unnerved.

LUCAS
Jesus...

JAXTON
And this Puck, it’s your protector?

KELLY
Sometimes. Other times, he just... watches. He’s not a savior. He marks. He makes sure the story costs something.

MAVERICK
And you brought that into this house?

KELLY
He follows.

CRACK. The floor beneath Kelly shifts with brutal force.

She gasps, yanked backward, violent, by the ankle

Kelly screams in pain as she hits the ground hard, dragged a few feet toward the dark hallway.

TICK. 9:13. ONCE. LOUD.

Silence.

Beat- everyone is completely still. Lucas stares at his hands, they're shaking.

MAVERICK
(half-whispering)
Maybe those mushrooms were way stronger than we thought.

HOLLY
(soft)
Are you okay?

KELLY
I think so.

JAXTON
(quiet)
Was that... Puck?

Shaking her head, still frozen on the floor, knees pulled in.

KELLY
(shaken)
No. Something much worse is already here.

She stares at the timepiece.

KELLY (CONT'D)
Puck's not a protector. He's the toll. Every time he's helped… someone else paid. That's why I didn't want to tell you.

MAVERICK
What the hell does that mean?

KELLY
Puck opens doors, carries balance. The evil in this house, the Feeder, eats what comes through.

LUCAS
I’m done.

JAXTON
Lucas—

LUCAS
(standing)
No Jax, I'm done. This isn't fun anymore. It's not even scary. It's sick.

He grabs his gear.

LUCAS (CONT’D)
(to Wesley)
And if this is a prank? It sucks.

HOLLY
Please don’t—

LUCAS
I’m sorry Holly. Maybe I'm having a bad trip, maybe its the meds... but I'm not having fun!

WESLEY
(to camera)
Rage-quit in real time. Classic. Drop a chat for epic haunted exits.

LIVESTREAM CHAT GLITCHES:

**"Don’t go."**

**"He’s not where you think."**

**"REWIND. REWIND. REWIND."**

Lucas steps outside. Front door CLICKS shut.

JAXTON
Lucas?

ON-SCREEN: Lucas appears in a different room. Flickers. Snaps back.

Beat... the group is frozen. They’re processing the last few minutes, all equally lost.

HOLLY
He just walked out and vanished.

MAVERICK
No. No fucking way.

He moves to the front door opening it, a solid stone wall behind it. Pounding on the wall then slamming the door shut.

Maverick storms to the side window, and grabs a fire poker, he swings. GLASS SHATTERS. Behind it: plaster. Wallpaper. More house.

MAVERICK (CONT'D)
What the hell!

KELLY
The house lies. They look like exits—until you use them.

HOLLY
Wesley. The feed.

Wesley's tablet screen, looping footage from ten minutes ago.

LIVESTREAM CHAT:

**"get out"**

**"get out"**

**"get out"**

Wesley stares. The loop won't break.

CUT TO:

INT. MORGUE - ALTERED REALITY

The front door opens into fog. MAVERICK stares out, desperate. Slams fists into the open air.

LUCAS
(shouting)
Maverick! I'm here! Mav!

Maverick SLAMS the door shut. It vanishes. A blank slab wall remains.

Lucas turns. He stands before a morgue that shouldn't exist. Rows of twisted BODY DRAWERS. A low MECHANICAL BUZZ hums. Cold, refrigerated air bites deep.

In the center of the room: a GURNEY. A BODY BAG atop it.

LUCAS (CONT'D)
(softly)
Dream logic. Mushroom logic.

He unzips the bag. Inside, a boy. Pale. Waterlogged. Eyes wide.

The boy's hand suddenly JERKS UP - GRABBING Lucas by the wrist. Cold. Wrinkled. Strong.

Lucas tries to pull back, but the grip tightens, YANKING him forward against the gurney.

His cheek scrapes the slick plastic.

LUCAS (CONT'D)
(whispers, breaking)
Jonah?

The boy's mouth opens. A CHORUS OF WHISPERS spills out. Lucas WRENCHES free. Water seeps from the drain. Then from the walls. Rushing.

The decayed room rearranges. Red light seeps from cracked tiles. Etched into them: "Start a story. Reveal the wound. Pay the cost. Only then can you end it."

He spins toward a RED DOOR. Wet paint. It pulses.

JONAH (O.S.)
You can't leave until you finish the game.

Lucas bolts for the red door.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - CONTINUOUS

The front door CREAKS open. Lucas stumbles in. Shuts it. Pale. Shaking.

HOLLY
Lucas!

LUCAS
(broken)
Don't go alone. The house isn't real. Not the way we think. It shifts.

WESLEY
(staggered)
What did you see?

LUCAS
Jonah. My friend. He drowned when we were ten. I dared him to cross the lake... and he did. I watched him disappear.

HOLLY
(gutted)
Oh my god...

LUCAS
And the house knew. It used it.

MAVERICK
That's it. Jax, this is insane. We done?

LUCAS
(pleading)
He said we can't leave until we finish the story.

KELLY
It's not done with us. We follow its rules—or it makes new ones.

JAXTON
Then we finish. Together.

They settle. Numb. Shaken.

WESLEY
(to camera)
Alright weirdos... we keep rolling. The story's got teeth.

TICK. TICK. 9:13.

Jaxton reads. New words BLEED through: "The chapel splits open. Something waits beneath." He tries to erase them. They remain.

JAXTON
(reading)
You descend into the undercroft. Stone steps. Blood altar.

The MAP shifts. A BLACK CIRCLE appears.

KELLY
That’s not from the game.

HOLLY
A void.

MAVERICK
Or a mouth.

TICK.

A SNAP from the kitchen. GLASS SHATTERS. Silence.

WESLEY
(nervous)
Air pressure.

KELLY
(low)
No. The story just turned a page.

The group barely breathes. The sound of the shattered glass still lingers like an echo.

HOLLY
Ok, screw this. I'm calling someone.

She pulls out her phone. A moment later, so do the others. All of them show ZERO BARS. No signal.

MAVERICK
Yeah, enough scary-movie crap for one night.

MAVERICK (CONT’D)
911 still work in... hell?

HOLLY
Just call!

She dials. It rings. Then her own voice answers.

HER VOICE (V.O.)
You’re still lying.

She drops the phone.

HOLLY
That was me.

Maverick dials. Static.

MAVERICK
(quiet)
Nothing.

Wesley checks the livestream.

CHAT SESSION:

**"Where’s the truth?"**

**"You promised them."**

**"Start over."**

**"No one’s watching."**

WESLEY
This... this isn’t live anymore.

KELLY
It never was. Not to them.

He pulls out his SATELLITE PHONE.

1 UNREAD MESSAGE: “It’s watching me. I didn’t trigger anything.”

WESLEY
(shows her)
From Billy. Today.

JAXTON
What does this demon want?

KELLY
To feed. Through fear. Through us. It writes a truth we’re not telling.

TICK. TICK. 9:13.

HOLLY
And when it finishes writing?

KELLY
It feeds again.

Beat- reality starts to sink in, it’s not a game of D&D anymore, it’s life and death. The floor RUMBLES. The map SHIFTS.

The BLACK CIRCLE GROWS.

The group sit in dim silence. Phones face-down.

MAVERICK
Someone brought this shit in.

HOLLY
Don’t start.

MAVERICK
This started when she showed up.

KELLY
You blaming me?

MAVERICK
You knew. You walked in haunted.

KELLY
You want to blame me because the house knows you?

HOLLY
Enough!

KELLY
(to Maverick)
What’s it writing about you?

He doesn’t answer.

LUCAS
Kelly’s not the problem.

JAXTON
(flat)
No. It’s us. The game’s just... reading us.

The MAP shifts. “AGREE” carves itself into the void.

HOLLY
It’s watching.

LUCAS
It wants us to look.

KELLY
Understand. Admit.

Kelly’s watch WHISPERS to her: “THIS ISN’T YOUR STORY. IT’S THEIRS.” Only she hears.

HOLLY
What if we don’t?

KELLY
It turns the page.

Jaxton shuts his binder.

JAXTON
Maybe it already has.

The BLACK CIRCLE PULSES with candlelight. A shared breath.

WESLEY
(hollow)
Let’s finish the story. Right, weirdos?

LIVESTREAM CHAT:

**"It’s not a show."**

**"Show more PUCK."**

WESLEY (CONT’D)
Then... the show goes on.

JAXTON (SOFT)
Ok...The undercroft stretches into tunnels. You hear someone breathing in the dark.
(beat)
One torch left. One path splits into three.

He looks up.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
One must go first.

MAVERICK
Can we skip the scary tunnel shit?

JAXTON
Roll a D20. Hope high.

They roll. HOLLY rolls a ONE. Critical fumble. She just stares at the die.

LUCAS
(to Holly)
I’ll go instead.

HOLLY
(soft)
No. The house wants my story.

JAXTON
You walk into the blackness of the tunnel. The stench of wet cloth and copper. A child's voice calling out.

HOLLY
She died because I let her.

Silence.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
I didn't wait. I lied. I pretended it was an accident.

TICK.

A DOOR APPEARS.

LUCAS
That wasn't there.

WESLEY
Not on playback.

The STREAM GLITCHES.

JAXTON
She opened the door.

KELLY
The house accepted it.

HOLLY
What's behind it?

KELLY
(reading map)
Two paths. One says "Her." One says "You."

JAXTON
You have to choose who stays.

HOLLY
(flat)
If I choose her, I stay. If I choose me, she stays lost.

MAVERICK
That's fucked.

KELLY
It tells the truth.

Holly rises.

JAXTON
You don’t have to.

HOLLY
She’s waited long enough.

She walks. Lucas grabs her hand, desperate. He won’t let go.

LUCAS
Holly, I love you.
(beat, breaking)
I’ve always loved you. Please...
don’t go.

The group sits in stunned silence. Holly’s hand trembles in his. For a moment, it looks like she’ll stay.

HOLLY
(soft, breaking)
I know, Lucas. I think I’ve always known.
(beat)
But that’s not the truth I carry.
And you can’t follow me into mine.

She presses his hand to her chest, then pulls away. Tears slip, but she doesn’t hide them.

HOLLY (CONT’D)
I love you. Just not in the way you need. Don’t make me another ghost.

She opens the door. A faint, familiar voice whispers inside—

BETH (V.O.)
Holly...?

Holly’s face collapses, but she steps through.

The SLAM echoes like a coffin lid.

Tears stream down Lucas’ face.

MAVERICK
Why are we still playing?!

JAXTON
It won’t let us stop.

CUT TO:

INT. HIDDEN ROOM - ALTERED REALITY

Darkness swallows HOLLY as the door seals behind her. Her flashlight flickers. The beam is weak. Unsteady.

A child’s jacket hangs from a rusted hook. A school backpack. One shoe.

She approaches, kneels. Breath short.

A faded bus pass dangles from the bag. She opens the front pocket. Inside, a laminated schedule. A torn drawing. Two stick girls.

One with a red ribbon.

HOLLY
(soft)
You were waiting...
(beat)
And I left.

She trembles.

HOLLY (CONT’D)
I said I’d wait by the gym. I just... I wanted to see my friends.
(beat)
You said you’d be fine. But you weren’t.

A soft scraping. She turns.

Her little sister, BETH STANTON (8), barefoot, still, wearing a red ribbon.

BETH
You forgot me.

HOLLY
I didn’t mean to. I swear.

BETH
I walked the whole way. You weren’t there.
(beat)
I got scared. The man in the car...

HOLLY breaks.

HOLLY
Don’t say it. Please.

BETH
You didn’t even notice I was gone.

The flashlight dies. Total black. A cold hand finds hers.

BETH (O.S.) (CONT’D)
You said you’d wait.

HOLLY
(breaking, tears)
I know.
(beat)
And I didn’t. I lied.

A red outline glows on the wall. A door. Incomplete.

Beth walks toward it. No footsteps. She turns.

BETH
If I go... will you come this time?

Holly steps forward. Tears streaming. She reaches for the girl's hand again. Her sister hesitates.

HOLLY
I love you. I never stopped. But I can’t stay. If I do... I lose myself.

BETH
So you choose you.

HOLLY
(devastated)
I don’t want to.
(beat)
But I have to.

A long silence. The girl looks down.

BETH
Just go.
(beat)
You always do.

The glow brightens. The girl vanishes.

HOLLY touches the red outline. It gives.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

HOLLY stands in the doorway. Pale. Haunted.

HOLLY
She was there. Beth.
(beat)
I saw her. And I let her stay.

Silence.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
We can't go back. None of us.

She sits. The TIMEPIECE TICKS.

JAXTON
(feeling responsibility
and a sadness)
Then we finish the story and end
this together.

The red door creaks shut. Gone.

WESLEY glances at his tablet. Screen flickers.

STREAM OVERLAY - distorts violently.

TEXT FLASHES: "Start a story. Reveal the wound. Pay the cost. Only then can you end it."

The chat freezes. Wesley stares, unsure who saw it.

WESLEY
Shit... feed's gone again.

LUCAS
Why does it even matter!

JAXTON
(trying to anchor them)
Focus, everyone!

WESLEY
Backup rig should've kicked in.
(beat)
He set it up, right?

KELLY
Wine cellar. It's set. Leave it, Wes.

WESLEY
Not a chance. Feed's gold. Thousands watching.
(beat)
You stay. Don't move.

He grabs a flashlight and exits.

MAVERICK
So this was all rigged and the game's over, right?

No response. KELLY stares at the timepiece.

CUT TO:

INT. WINE CELLAR - REALITY - CONTINUOUS

Dust. Shadow. The low hum of a generator.

Wesley edges in, phone-light trembling.

WESLEY
It's fine. Just Billy, late as always. Probably hiding, messing with me—

A SCARE TRAP triggers. A skeletal animatronic LUNGES.

WESLEY (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
Fuck—Billy!

He turns a corner.

BILLY slumped against the stone wall. Skin blistered. A SPIRAL burned into his chest, glowing faintly.

Wesley stumbles forward.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
Billy...?

He drops to his knees. Reaches out—his hand comes up slick with blood.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
No... no, no, no—

The SPIRAL pulses. Whispers crawl out, not Billy's voice but something parasitic, inside his head.

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
You sold the story.

Wesley jerks back, gagging. Vomits onto the stone.

WESLEY
I didn't—I didn't know—

The VOICE grows louder, echoing off the walls.

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
You brought them.

Wesley claws his way up the steps, scrambling, desperate to escape.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - MOMENTS LATER

The door SLAMS open. Wesley BURSTS in, bloody, shaking.

WESLEY
(hoarse, broken)
We have to go. We have to—now.

The others freeze.

KELLY
Wesley, what—

WESLEY
Billy's dead. He's... burned, carved open, the spiral—
(voice cracking)
I touched him, he was—oh god—

MAVERICK
You're kidding, right?

WESLEY
(snarling, snapping)
Do I look like I'm fucking kidding?!

He grabs the front door. YANKS. Nothing. The house GROANS back at him.

Wesley collapses against the wall. Sobs rack his chest. Words spill out, jagged and unstoppable.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
It wasn't supposed to be this. It was just a show. A stupid stream.
(choking)
We rigged the scares, the traps, all of it.

He buries his face in his hands, trembling.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
I needed it to work. Rent's overdue. My cards are maxed. Every month I'm drowning, and nobody gives a shit. But fear—fear cuts through everything.
(beat — he looks up, wild-eyed)
When you're scared, that's the only time you're real. No masks. No filters. That's all I wanted.

He collapses into sobbing.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
I just wanted them to watch me.

The TIMEPIECE TICKS.

The MAP BLEEDS in thick, dark letters: "WESLEY, TELL THE TRUTH."

SILENCE. The group stares at him, rattled to the core.

A new DOOR forms. Rounded. No handle. Just shadow.

The LIVESTREAM tablet flickers to life.

LIVESTREAM CHAT FLOODS:

**"Tell the truth."**

**"Let the story finish."

**"We're still watching."**

KELLY
It's asking you to testify.

JAXTON
If it is rigged Wes, let's just stop... enough already.

Wesley looks at them. At the camera. At the door.

He walks to it. Shaking. Stops in the threshold. Turns to camera.

WESLEY
I wanted fear. I wanted clicks. I brought you all in.
(beat)
I'm sorry.

He steps inside.

From the tablet, APPLAUSE.

The DOOR SNAPS SHUT.

INT. THEATER ROOM - ALTERED REALITY - CONTINUOUS

The screen flickers. Shadows coil. Wesley staggers forward, blood on his hands, manic.

WESLEY
(pleading, screaming)
Fear is the only thing that's real! Don't you see? When you're terrified, that's when you're honest!

The HOUSE shudders. A hundred WHISPERS ripple through the walls.

VOICES (O.S.)
Truth. Truth. Truth.

Wesley freezes. His own words echo back, distorted. He steadies himself, forces a manic grin, one more showman's mask.

WESLEY
(to the unseen crowd)
What's up, weirdos... you still watching?
(beat — voice trembling)
Tonight's special feature... me.

He spreads his arms wide like a performer on stage. A spotlight of sickly light pins him.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
No edits. No retakes. Just raw terror. Just truth.
(choking)
I wanted fear. I wanted clicks. I
(MORE)

WESLEY (CONT'D)
brought you all in for the show.
Isn't this what you came for?

The screen erupts with the group's faces, Jaxton, Holly, Lucas, Kelly, Maverick, each frozen in pure fear. Wesley's philosophy reflected back, magnified, undeniable.

He laughs, a broken, hollow sound, halfway between sobbing and a livestream bit.

WESLEY (CONT'D)
Smash that like button, right?
Don't forget to subscribe...
(voice breaking)
Please... don't stop watching me.

The VOICES thunder, overlapping, swallowing him:

VOICES (O.S.)
We see you. We see you. We see you.

The shadows surge. Wesley SCREAMS as he's pulled into the screen, his own performance devouring him. The last thing visible is his hand, still raised in a host's wave.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

The tablet lies on the table. Frozen frame: Wesley's grin, hollow and trembling.

The group stares in stunned silence. No one breathes.

Maverick rips the flask from Holly's hand, downs it. His hands shake.

MAVERICK
(hoarse)
That... that wasn't an act.

Lucas presses his palms to his eyes, breaking. Kelly sits rigid, the watch ticking like a metronome of doom.

LUCAS
He tried to... host his own death.

HOLLY
(haunted)
He wanted them to love him. And it ate him instead.

Jaxton flips his notebook open with trembling fingers. New words bleed across the page, not his own: “The story consumes its storyteller.”

JAXTON
(whisper)
It used him... like it’s using all of us.

The house GROANS, a low exhale. The chandelier above sways, glass tinkling.

KELLY
(low, cold)
The Feeder’s awake now. It won’t stop. Not until it’s fed enough truth.

The MAP bleeds darker. The BLACK CIRCLE spreads, swallowing the drawn terrain.

The group sits in the awful silence left by Wesley’s performance collapse, his manic grin burned into them.

For the first time, no one jokes. No one deflects.

They know, this story will finish, with or without them.

CUT TO:

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - REALITY - NIGHT

An old pickup truck rumbles to a stop. Fog curls around the trees like smoke.

Inside, LUCY WILLIS (24), athletic, alert, eyes sharp but tired. She kills the engine. For a moment, she just sits. Breathing. Her hand clutches a PHOTO, she and JAXTON with their parents. A faded family portrait, the last one before the crash. On the back, in Jaxton’s handwriting: “Sept. 13 — Never forget.”

LUCY (V.O.)
I promised I’d protect him. After the crash, I swore I’d never let him face the world alone. And I broke that promise.

Her eyes sting. She presses the photo to her chest.

The passenger seat glows with the light of a LAPTOP. She hits the trackpad. The frozen livestream crackles back to life.

A frame: WESLEY performing for the camera. Another: JAXTON at the table. Older than she remembers. Tired. Haunted.

Her jaw clenches. She dials his phone.

LUCY
Come on... pick up.

It rings.

Then, a VOICE answers. Her own.

HER VOICE (V.O.)
You're already late.

She stiffens. The call drops. ZERO BARS.

LUCY
(shaken whisper)
What the hell is this place?

She looks out the window. The AUDI SUV. The JEEP. Silent. All the house windows black.

She grips the photo tighter.

LUCY (CONT'D)
(soft)
Please be okay, Jax. Not tonight.
Not on their day.

She steps out. Cold FOG hits hard. She grabs her backpack and throws it over her shoulder.

LUCY (CONT'D)
(to herself)
I left you once. Not again.

She moves toward the entrance, low and careful, scanning the shadows.

From the woods, faint LAUGHTER. Or APPLAUSE. She freezes. Holds her breath.

The sound dies. She forces herself forward.

EXT. RED HALLOW LODGE - REALITY - MOMENTS LATER

She reaches the veranda. Knocks. Pounds harder.

Silence. Nothing answers.

She circles the house perimeter. Branches snag her jacket. Her breath quickens.

A faint SICKLY GREEN LIGHT spills from a basement window. Cracked open. Beckoning.

She crouches. Peers inside.

LUCY
(pleading, quiet)
Let me in.

She forces the window wider. Crawls forward. Drops inside.

INT. WINE CELLAR - NIGHT

Darkness. Her hands scrape on stone. Jeans rip against the sill.

She raises her flashlight. The beam slices across the cellar and lands on BILLY.

His body slumped against the wall. Skin blistered, split. A SPIRAL burned into his chest. Faintly glowing.

LUCY
(horrified)
Oh my god... oh my god...

Her hand flies to her mouth. She stumbles backward, nearly dropping the light. Her breath breaks, ragged.

She turns toward the faint glow under the door at the far end of the cellar. Runs for it. Desperate to reach her brother.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - NIGHT

The FLOOR RUMBLES. Dice rattle across the table. The MAP bleeds again, ink soaking like open veins.

A single word rises through parchment: NEXT.

MAVERICK
(low, rattled)
What the hell does that mean?

KELLY
(soft, certain)
It means we're still inside its story. And it's not done feeding.

The tablet VIBRATES, new comments cascade across the dead glass.

LIVESTREAM CHAT:

**“stay live”**

**“don’t cut”**

**“this is history”**

Maverick stares between the scrolling chat and his friends. His chest heaves. His composure fractures.

MAVERICK
No more audience. No more circus.

He YANKS the rig’s power cord. Sparks. But the feed doesn’t die. The stream STAYS LIVE. Comments crawl across the lifeless screen.

MAVERICK (CONT’D)
(rising, breaking)
This stops now. Burn the map. Break the game. End it.

He grabs the campaign binder, hurls it. Tears at the map with shaking hands.

The HOUSE GROANS. Walls flex inward like lungs exhaling. The chandelier SWINGS hard overhead.

KELLY
(low, sharp)
Don’t. Every time someone quits... it takes more.

The torn map flutters to the floor. Bloodstained silence. Kelly’s timepiece TICKS ONCE. LOUD.

MAVERICK
(panic, survival mode)
We have to fight back.

HOLLY
(snapping, unraveling)
Fight what, Maverick? The walls? The story? Each other? Tell me how!

JAXTON
(quiet, breaking)
If we stop... it chooses.

KELLY
(soft)
And it punishes.

The MAP PULSES. A second sheet unfurls across the table. Blank. Ink slithers like veins.

A single word writes itself: CHOOSE.

HOLLY
(whispered)
It wants one of us to volunteer.

MAVERICK
(snarling)
To hell with it. I told you, burn the damn thing.

He reaches again. The map WRITHES. A scorching hiss curls toward his hand. He recoils, cursing, eyes wet.

Jaxton’s eyes fix on the page.

JAXTON
(cracking)
We’re not choosing characters anymore.
(beat)
We’re choosing who bleeds next.

A sick silence falls. Lucas’s voice cuts through, flat, fatal.

LUCAS
It’s already decided.

The MAP bleeds a name. Red ink spreads like a wound: HOLLY.

HOLLY stares at the map and dice like they’ve betrayed her. Her throat tightens. She forces steel through trembling hands.

HOLLY
Of course it’s me.

LUCAS
(urgent)
Holly—wait—

HOLLY
(hard, covering)
No. I’m good. Let’s do it. Let’s see what other nightmares I locked away.

MAVERICK
(voice cracks, brittle with anger)
Maybe Puck's pulling the strings. Maybe he picks who gets hit. Maybe he's saving his favorite. Kelly.

All eyes pivot to her. The accusation hangs heavy.

Kelly doesn't flinch. Rage simmers beneath her calm.

KELLY
I didn't ask for him. Or any of this.
(beat)
You think I enjoy watching this house chew through people I just met? Through people I... actually care about?

Silence. Breathing syncs with the house, jagged, terrified.

The MAP bleeds again. New geometry. New cruelty.

THE MIRRORED CHAMBER. Broken reflections surround a black altar.

Jaxton's hand jerks, almost possessed. Words tumble out, not fully his.

JAXTON
You enter a round chamber. Cold marble. Six mirrors. But they're not reflections. They're watching.

HOLLY
Jaxton...?

Jaxton blinks hard. Sweat beads at his temple. His voice shaky.

JAXTON
(quiet, fighting)
I can't stop it. The story's making me...

LUCAS
(pressing)
What else is in the room?

JAXTON
(straining)
An altar. A locked chest. Syla Veilshade... has the key.

The chest SHIMMERS into being. Solid. Wrong. The air chills around it.

HOLLY
What happens if I don't open it?

Jaxton's voice twists. His lips move, but something else speaks through.

JAXTON / PARASITIC VOICE
(possessed)
You won't get out.

HOLLY
Who said that?

JAXTON
(quiet, rattled)
I think I did.

KELLY
(urgent)
Holly, don't.

HOLLY
We never got to not do it. That's what you said, Jax.

She reaches. Fingers brush the chest. Her hand passes through it like smoke.

The LIGHTS GLITCH. The walls SHRIEK, voices of children, of grief.

From beyond the parlor, a SCREAM.

LUCY'S scream.

The parlor doors SLAM SHUT.

INT. PARLOR - ALTER REALITY - NIGHT

The door CREAKS open. LUCY stumbles in, mud-streaked, sleeve torn, eyes wild. Her backpack clings to her like armor.

The CAMERA RIG flickers on by itself.

ONSCREEN: An empty parlor. One chair. A figure materializes JAXTON. But wrong. Smooth-faced. Uncanny. Hollow imitation.

JAXTON (O.S.)
You're already inside.

LUCY
(desperate)
Jaxton? JAXTON!

She bolts to the doors. Locked. Sealed. Her fists hammer until they bleed.

LUCY (CONT'D)
Open! OPEN!

The tablet lights: "LUCIANA WILLIS — YOUR TURN."

LUCY (CONT'D)
(shaking her head)
No. That's not me. That's not real.

The MAP ignites across the wall, burning letters into plaster: "THE WAITING ROOM."

Lucy stumbles back.

Onscreen: her mouth moves, but the voice is not hers.

The camera locks on her.

PARASITIC WHISPER (O.S.)
It's always recording.

Lucy's eyes brim with panic. She turns toward the dark, screaming.

LUCY
Jax, don't let it take you too—

The SOUND CRACKS. Her body jerks, GONE.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY / ALTER REALITY - CONTINUOUS

Chaos detonates. Adrenaline becomes panic. Grief rips the air.

JAXTON
(slamming door)
LUCY! LUCY!!

His voice cracks. He pounds until his knuckles split.

HOLLY
(horrified)
She was right there, we have to get her out!

MAVERICK swings a chair at the handle. Sparks. Wood splinters. No give.

MAVERICK
Come on! We can break it!

KELLY
(snapping, trembling)
STOP! You'll make it worse!

LUCAS
(panicked)
Worse?! She's trapped, Kelly! What the hell does worse mean?!

The TIMEPIECE in Kelly's pocket TICKS. Rapid. Uneven. Like a dying heart.

JAXTON
(voice shredding)
Lucy, listen to me! Don't trust anything it shows you! Don't trust it!

The walls PULSE. A LOW GROAN shudders through the beams, beast-like.

KELLY
(hollow)
We're not rescuing anyone. We're trading turns.

A silence heavier than screams.

HOLLY
(breaking)
What... do you mean?

Kelly's hands shake. Tears burn as she forces the words out.

KELLY
I've been here before.

Everyone turns. Disbelief. Fear.

KELLY (CONT'D)
Thirteen years ago. My brother was eight. We were on vacation, invited to a game night. Some older kids, my cousin's friends. I didn't even want to go. But I didn't want to be the weird girl who stayed home.

She swallows hard. Her voice begins to break.

KELLY (CONT'D) (CONT'D)
We played. Just like you. Just like this. But the game didn't end. The demon in the house wouldn't let it.

Maverick stares, wide-eyed.

MAVERICK
(stunned)
The Miller murders... that was you?

KELLY
They said I survived. That's what the papers wrote. But I didn't. Not really.
(beat)
No one believed me. They blamed my cousin. Called it a psychotic break.

She looks at Jaxton. Then the sealed door.

KELLY (CONT'D)
The truth is... I let Puck save me. I ran. And the toll was my brother.

Her voice collapses. Tears streak.

KELLY (CONT'D)
I thought if I never told the story again, it couldn't find me.

The MAP BLEEDS. Dice twitch. The table shakes with her confession.

KELLY (CONT'D)
Then Wesley emailed. Said he had a house for a stream. The address, I knew it. But I came anyway. To stop it.

HOLLY
(furious)
Then why wait? Why not warn us?

KELLY
(raw)
Would you have believed me? A stranger claiming she crawled out of an urban legend? I thought I could help without dragging you in. But the moment the map bled... I knew.

LUCAS
(choked)
What does it want?

KELLY
To get out. And to gorge on every fear it can before it does.

The house SHUDDERS. Breath becomes frost. The ceiling bulges, lowering, as if the weight of the house is sinking onto them. BLACK WATER leaks from plaster, running down the wallpaper like veins.

HOLLY
(whispered)
Is it... shrinking?

LUCAS
(desperate)
No. No, it’s just in our heads. Has to be.

MAVERICK
(gasping)
Then why does it feel like my ribs are caving in?

A MIRROR bleeds into existence above the fireplace. Slick, black glass.

Maverick stares. His reflection, older. Hollow-eyed. A wedding ring glints. Beside him, a blurred man’s hand rests on his shoulder.

MAVERICK (CONT’D)
(hissing)
That’s not me.

KELLY
Maverick—

MAVERICK
(spiraling)
That’s NOT ME. NOT ME!

The reflection GRINS. The MIRROR SHATTERS outward. Glass explodes. Maverick drops, screaming, shards cutting his palms.

The FIREPLACE ERUPTS into blue flame.

The parlor doors SLAM OPEN—

Lucy is gone.

Jaxton collapses to his knees. His scream is raw, breaking.

JAXTON
(shredded)
LUCY!!

HOLLY
(devestated)
Oh my god... she’s gone.

Jaxton SLAMS his fists against the floor until blood streaks the boards.

JAXTON
(sobbing)
No... no, she’s not! She’s not!

The MAP TWITCHES. A new vein spreads across parchment.

KELLY
(hollow)
We lost her.
(beat)
And now it’s picking again.

They turn. Maverick kneels in broken glass, shaking, the echo of his reflection’s grin still burning in his eyes.

The house waits.

INT. THE WAITING ROOM - ALTER REALITY

Lucy blinks. She’s no longer in the parlor.

Cheap vinyl chairs. A buzzing fluorescent light flickers above. A RECEPTION DESK. Empty.

Faceless figures sit frozen in the waiting area. Silent. Breathless.

A CLOCK on the wall TWITCHES instead of ticking.

LUCY
(whispers)
Where am I…?

She rises, trembling, moving toward the desk.

A RECEPTIONIST appears. Back turned. Rigid. Hair taut. Suit too tight. Still as stone.

LUCY (CONT'D)
I need to leave.
(beat)
I don't belong here.

The receptionist turns, no face. Just a BLACK, CRACKED MIRROR.

In one shard, JAXTON as a boy. Flashlight in hand, smiling. In another shard, LUCY'S OWN REFLECTION. Crying.

A CLIPBOARD slides toward her. The page blank. A PEN scratches on its own: "WHAT PART OF HIM DO YOU WANT TO KEEP?"

The pen begins sketching JAXTON'S SILHOUETTE before she even touches it.

Lucy staggers back, horrified.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

Maverick is dragged from the shattered mirror shards. Bleeding. Shaking.

The ceiling BUCKLES downward. The walls pulse inward, closer. The floor groans like it's breathing.

KELLY
(terrified)
It's punishing him.

JAXTON
(haunted, breaking)
No… it's showing him.

The MAP curls inward, edges burning.

One word bleeds across in thick black ink: SACRIFICE.

The D20 rolls itself. ONE.

JAXTON (CONT'D)
(voice breaking)
A critical fail…

HOLLY
(pleading to the house)
Then take me! You hear me? Take ME!

Silence. The flames gutter. The map burns again.

A name bleeds across: JAXTON.

Beneath it: “THE STORY BELONGS TO ME NOW.”

The DICE TRAY SPLINTERS. The NARRATOR KING MINIATURE shatters into dust. From the base, a DARK HOLE opens.

LUCAS
No. No no no no—

Jaxton steps forward, tears in his eyes. His body shaking like it’s no longer his.

JAXTON
(soft)
It was never mine to control…
(beat)
But it’s mine now to pay for.

HOLLY lunges for him.

HOLLY
No! Don’t you dare! We need you, Jax! I need you—

Jaxton cups her face. His hand trembles, but his voice steadies.

JAXTON
You gave me family when I had nothing. You kept me here when I wanted to disappear. I’ll never forget you, Holly. Ever. I love you now, I’ve loved you forever.

He kisses her forehead. Holly collapses into sobs.

Jaxton forces a smile through his tears.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
(quiet)
I love you guys.

The HOUSE GROANS. Dice scatter across the table. Every single die rolls a ONE.

The MAP flashes: CRITICAL FAILURE. NO ESCAPE.

CUT TO:

INT. THE WAITING ROOM - ALTER REALITY - SAME TIME

Lucy pounds the mirror-faced receptionist’s desk.

LUCY
(screaming)
Jax! Jax, don’t you dare leave me again!

On the cracked mirror, JAXTON’S FACE PRESSES against the glass from the other side, suffocating, blurred in smoke.

Lucy SLAMS the glass, sobbing.

LUCY (CONT’D)
(crying out)
Forever twins, remember? You promised! You promised, Jax!

BACK TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY / ALTER REALITY

Jaxton glances upward, as if hearing her through the walls.

JAXTON
(soft)
I hear you, Luce. Always.

He steps toward the smoke. The void PULLS him, but it does not close. His chair remains, empty. A hollow absence.

The MAP burns. The miniature table collapses inward.

CUT TO:

INT. THE WAITING ROOM - ALTER REALITY

Lucy SCREAMS, clawing at the glass.

LUCY
(devastated)
I told you I’d protect you! I told you—

The receptionist turns. Mirror face etched with a single word: CONTINUE.

The clipboard writes: “THE NEXT DOOR IS OPEN.”

Lucy shakes, breaking. She grips the door handle, carved with a SPIRAL around an EYE.

She sobs, then turns it.

CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

The group collapses in shock. Holly sobs uncontrollably, clutching Jaxton's empty chair. Maverick smashes his fist into the floor, bloodied. Lucas can't breathe.

Kelly clutches the TIMEPIECE like it's burning her hand.

KELLY
(whispers)
Puck… help us.

Nothing.

Then—MAVERICK CONVULSES. His throat bulges. Black mist seeps out.

Holly and Lucas panic.

HOLLY
MAV! What's wrong?!

MAVERICK
(choking)
It's inside—

He sees his SHADOW SPLIT. Another him. Grinning.

MAVERICK (CONT'D)
Get it out of me!

Lucas grabs him.

LUCAS
Hold on, Mav!

Kelly steps forward, tears streaming, clutching the TIMEPIECE.

KELLY
(to herself)
It's me. It's always been me.

She kneels, pressing the TIMEPIECE to Maverick's chest.

KELLY (CONT'D)
You want a toll?
(beat)
Fine. I'm offering it.

MAVERICK convulses harder.

TICKING RETURNS. FAST. LOUD.

MAVERICK
What are you doing—KELLY, STOP—
Don’t trade for me—DON’T—

A cold wind rips through the parlor. Lights EXPLODE.

HOLLY
(screaming)
KELLY!

Kelly’s hair lifts. Eyes shimmer silver.

KELLY
(whispers)
Protect them.

From behind, PUCK MANIFESTS. A ghost half-formed. Eyes like shattered mirrors.

PUCK
(inhuman)
The balance is kept.

He touches her shoulder.

COMPLETE DARKNESS.

When LIGHT RETURNS. KELLY IS GONE.

Only the TIMEPIECE remains. Ticking beside a BLACK SCORCH MARK.

HOLLY
(sobbing)
No—no no no—KELLY!

She collapses. Her sobs shatter the others. Lucas shakes, horrified.

MAVERICK
(whispers, broken)
She saved me.

TICK. TICK. 9:13. GLOWING.

The timepiece SLIDES toward HOLLY. She backs away.

HOLLY
(crying)
No, please. Don’t pick me—

It glows brighter. An unnatural, searing BLUE.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
(broken)
I don't want to die.

The TICKING grows LOUDER. Like a countdown.

Suddenly— A LAUGH. Low. Layered. Ancient. Vibrates through the walls like a war drum. NOT PUCK. Something OLDER. HUNGRIER.

PARASITIC WHISPER (O.S.)
It can't protect you.

The MAP IGNITES. A new section scorches into the table: THE PROJECTION ROOM.

CUT TO:

INT. THE PROJECTION ROOM - ALTER REALITY

A claustrophobic chamber. Walls the color of nicotine. The BUZZ of a dying ballast. Dust spirals inside a thin cone of projector light.

Six metal CHAIRS face a stained SCREEN. No one sits in them. Yet.

Behind Lucy, ancient 16mm REELS HUM. Tape slaps. A stutter that's almost a heartbeat.

ONSCREEN: LITTLE LUCY (5) screams into a pillow, shoulders shaking.

LUCY
No.

The REEL swaps by itself.

ONSCREEN: TEEN LUCY argues with her PARENTS. Storms out. The door hits the frame. JAXTON lingers on the stairs, a D20 in his hand. Tears streak his face.

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
Watch.

Lucy inches closer, breath fogging in the projector's beam.

ONSCREEN: BASEMENT. Jaxton older holds that same D20 like a relic.

JAXTON (O.S.)
Lucy said she'd play. She promised.

Lucy’s hand clamps her mouth.

Cut. Flicker. Jam.

ONSCREEN: LUCY in a hallway. She glances back. Keeps walking. Behind her, Jaxton’s silhouette shrinks.

JAXTON (O.S.) (CONT’D)
You never kept your promise!

The AUDIO WARPS, as if drowning. The FRAME BUBBLES—

BLACK.

Then, JAXTON’S FACE APPEARS. Not film. Real. Too close. The light catches wet eyes.

JAXTON (O.S.) (CONT’D)
You left me in the dark. You lied.

The celluloid IGNITES. Flame eats him to white.

CUT TO:

INT. THE VOID - ALTER REALITY

Infinite dark. A sliver of stage light drops from nowhere.

A TABLE. A DM SCREEN.

Jaxton sits behind it, alone. Cards spread like a ritual circle.

His hand shakes as he flips the first: LUCY’S PHOTO (10) taped to cardstock. THE CARD: “THE RETURN.”

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
She’s watching now. But so am I.

The VOID SHUDDERS. Five more CARDS slide into place. One face-down card pulses faintly: “THE END.”

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.) (CONT’D)
Finish the story.

Jaxton swallows. Doesn’t flip it.

CUT TO:

INT. THE PROJECTION ROOM - ALTER REALITY

The SCREEN is a dead square. The PROJECTOR HUMS.

A TABLE SLAMS down in front of Lucy. Dust blooms like breath.

Six chairs. Burned paper. DICE etched with hairline cracks. Bone carved MINIS that don't quite hold still.

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
You've always watched. Now… they're watching you.

The seats FILL with SHADOWS, featureless but familiar in posture. They all TURN to Lucy.

SHADOWS (IN LUCY'S VOICE)
Say the words, Lucy. Say it so it's real.

The burned paper quivers.

New ink crawls across like veins:

"ONE MUST BETRAY. ONE MUST BLEED."

"SPEAK. OR THEY ALL FALL."

Lucy's fingers dig into the table edge until her knuckles go bloodless.

LUCY
(shaking)
I'm not part of this. I'm not—

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
Speak the choice. Name the traitor. Name the blame.

The SCREEN FLARES to life.

MIDDLE SCHOOL: MAVERICK shoulder checks Jaxton, grinning for a crowd.

A DARK CORNER: HOLLY kisses Jaxton, then pulls away like she burned herself.

A STAIRWELL: LUCAS, whispering to Holly, "Jaxton doesn't care." He does.

Lucy staggers, fury and shame warring behind her eyes.

LUCY
Stop. Stop—

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
Say it.

The SHADOWS LEAN IN. The projector BUZZ drills her skull.

LUCY
(breaking open)
Holly betrays him. Maverick bleeds.

A jagged CRACK fractures the screen.

WHITE detonation—

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - SAME TIME

Lucy GASPING awake, face down on warped hardwood. The room has SHRUNK, ceiling sagging low, BLACK WATER threading down like veins, breathing with the house.

HOLLY, LUCAS, and MAVERICK stand over her.

HOLLY
(numb)
We heard you.

MAVERICK
(quiet, dazed)
What did you do?

The TIMEPIECE lies beside Lucy, TICKING IN REVERSE. 9:13… 9:12… 9:11… then slams back to 9:13.

LUCY
(choking)
It made me choose, I didn't—

LUCAS
You chose us.

The tablet flickers to a live feed that isn't theirs.

ON-SCREEN COMMENTS CASCADE:

**"get ready to watch him bleed."**

**"roll again."**

**"traitor marked."**

Lucy crawls back, wrecked.

HOLLY
(voice shaking)
Say it again. What you said.

LUCY
(pleading)
It wasn't real— the room — it put the words—

MAVERICK
(anger cracking)
You picked me to bleed.

LUCY
(raw)
I didn't want to!

HOLLY
(disbelief)
You looked at me when you said "betray." You didn't blink.

LUCAS
Guys—

The TIMEPIECE SPINS. Faster. Louder. The DICE lift and HOVER.

LUCAS (CONT'D)
It's doing it again—

Maverick's nose starts to BLEED. Then his ears. He looks at his palm as a long, ragged TEAR opens across the lifeline, bleeding like a mouth.

MAVERICK
(scream)
AHHHH—

He staggers backward, leaving a red trail.

INT. HALLWAY - REALITY - CONTINUOUS

Maverick stumbles through the corridor, hand clamped, bleeding, disoriented. The HOUSE seems to lean him toward a specific door.

He SLAMS through it—

INT. MIRROR ROOM - ALTER REALITY - CONTINUOUS

Bare. Dim. No windows. No furniture. Just the bulb's FLICKER and an ANTIQUE MIRROR leaning on the far wall.

Maverick steadies himself against it, breathing hard.

MAVERICK
(to himself)
Get it together, Mav. Come on—

He looks up.

JAXTON stares back from the mirror with black, bottomless eyes. Smiling wrong.

MIRROR JAXTON
(almost gentle)
You know why she picked you.

Maverick spins. Empty room.

Back to the mirror, only his reflection now… but his REFLECTION'S EYES BLEED.

Behind him (mirror-only), SCHOOL PHOTOS materialize and hang in the air like evidence:

- Jaxton alone at lunch.

— Holly's secret kiss.

— Lucas scrolling a chat where Maverick's texts are screenshotted and laughed at.

— Maverick's unsent draft to Lucas: "I think it's you. It's always been you."

MAVERICK
(terrified)
Stop. Please—

The bulb stutters. The ROOM BREATHES.

The photos PEEL AWAY. The mirror goes OILY BLACK.

JAXTON APPEARS AGAIN — wronger. Smile cutting too wide.

MIRROR JAXTON
You can leave. Just pick.

MAVERICK
(cracking)
Pick…?

MIRROR JAXTON
Who dies next.

A slick SILVER DOOR rises open in the wall. It reflects nothing.

MAVERICK
No.

MIRROR JAXTON
One word. That's all. Say the name.

The mirror flashes a fusillade: LUCY'S blood-slick hands… HOLLY burying her face after the kiss… LUCAS's lie… JAXTON'S empty chair.

MAVERICK
(sobbing)
Stop—

MIRROR JAXTON
(soft, relentless)
SAY IT.

Maverick drops to his knees. Fingers in his hair, nails tearing scalp. Blood patters the floor.

MAVERICK
(a ruined whisper)
…Holly.

The SILVER DOOR CREAKS open.

Maverick staggers toward it, freezes.

IN THE MIRROR, HOLLY convulses, eyes rolling, a line of bright red threading down her lip.

MAVERICK (CONT'D)
(shocked)
No… I didn't mean—

MIRROR JAXTON
You didn't choose.
(beat)
You confessed.

BLACK.

INT. PARLOR - SAME TIME

The group surrounds the table.

Lucy still shaking, her hands stained red.

Lucas watches the dice trembling in the tray.

LUCAS
(low, unsettled)
Something's wrong.

HOLLY
(urgent, breaking)
Where is he?

Suddenly—HOLLY GASPS. Her eyes widen. She clutches her chest.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
I— I can't—

She collapses to her knees. Chokes. BLOOD spills from her mouth.

LUCY
(screaming)
HOLLY!

Her fingers twist unnaturally, joints locking backwards. Blood streams from her nose, her ears.

Lucas drops beside her, frantic.

LUCAS
She's seizing—HELP HER!

The dice RATTLE on the table. The MAP bleeds VEINS of BLACK INK.

LUCY
(pleading)
Please, please make it stop!

Holly's body jolts. Once. Twice. Then... still.

Her chest deflates. A final shudder.

A single drop of blood lands on the TIMEPIECE.

It glows. Then fades.

Silence.

HOLLY lies motionless. Eyes open. Staring.

Lucy kneels beside her. Shaking. Hands soaked in red.

FOOTSTEPS. Maverick enters from the hall, stopping cold when he sees Holly's body.

MAVERICK
(shattered)
...No.

Lucas cradles Holly, rocking her like she might wake.

LUCAS
(raw)
She's dead.

Maverick freezes, horror spreading across his face.

MAVERICK
(voice cracking)
I didn't—

Lucas rises slowly. FIRE in his eyes.

LUCAS
(snarling)
But you said it.

Lucy stumbles between them, hands out.

LUCY
(desperate)
He didn't mean to. Lucas, it made him—

LUCAS
It's always making us.

He SCREAMS. Kicks the table. Miniatures FLY, as dice scatter like teeth across the floor.

The MAP PULSES. A deep HEARTBEAT in the wood.

The livestream glitches. Faces in the chat warp into static mouths.

MAVERICK
(hollow, broken)
It's not asking anymore.

WHISPERS crawl through the room.

PARASITIC WHISPERS (O.S.)
Lucy. Maverick. Lucas.

Maverick steps forward, trembling.

MAVERICK
(to the house)
Take me. Not them.

The TIMEPIECE TICKS, backwards. Faster. Louder.

LUCAS
(spitting)
It’s her. It picked her.

Everyone stares at Lucy.

LUCY
(quiet, haunted)
Maybe it let me in because it already knew.

MAVERICK
Let you in?

LUCY
(a whisper, breaking)
No one asked how I got inside.
(beat)
I didn’t break in. The window opened for me. Like it was waiting.

A silence heavier than air itself.

LUCAS
(realization)
What if this whole thing... was meant for you?

TICK. TICK. 9:13. The sound echoes like a funeral bell.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - MOMENTS AFTER HOLLY’S DEATH

The room is paralyzed.

Lucy wipes Holly’s blood from her hands.

Maverick can’t meet Lucas’s eyes.

The map pulses faintly, flickering like skin stretched too thin.

On the table, the TIMEPIECE glows.

A CARD slowly RISES from the map.

Black ink across its face: “THE RULES.”

The lights dim. The house RUMBLES, like it’s clearing its throat.

LUCY
(reading it, soft)
“Start a story. Reveal the wound. Pay the cost. Only then can you end it.”

The card CRUMBLES to ash in her hands.

They stare at the soot drifting down.

LUCY (CONT’D)
(whispers, horrified clarity)
That’s what it’s doing.
(beat)
It’s not just killing us. It’s... playing through us.

LUCAS
(rage boiling)
Bullshit. That’s not a rule. That’s a curse.

Maverick swallows. Silent. His eyes wet.

MAVERICK
(almost to himself)
Maybe it’s both.

LUCY
(remembering, breaking)
Jaxton said… it only moves if we give it something true.

Silence. The weight of it pins them all.

The TIMEPIECE ticks once. TICK.

The stream overlay glitches. For a single frame: “START A STORY. REVEAL THE WOUND. PAY THE COST. ONLY THEN CAN YOU END IT.”

Then gone.

The table bleeds. Dice split. A single word glows in red: WITNESS.

The group is frozen.

Then, a faint MECHANICAL WHIRR.

LUCAS
What is that...?

LUCY
(quietly)
That sound...

They follow it.

INT. DEN - REALITY - MOMENTS LATER

An OLD CRT TELEVISION sits in the corner. Dusty. Dead for decades.

Beneath it, a VHS PLAYER whirs.

The machine EJECTS a tape.

Label: “MILLER GAME NIGHT.”

Maverick stares, paling.

MAVERICK
(whispers)
That... wasn’t here before.

Lucy, shaking, takes the tape. Slides it back in. Presses PLAY.

The screen hisses with STATIC.

INT. RED HALLOW LODGE - VHS FOOTAGE - NIGHT (1990)

A grainy, flickering video. Children crowd a living room. Pizza boxes, birthday balloons, a D&D board spread across the carpet.

They laugh. Roll dice.

One boy in a wizard hat, JAMES MILLER (14), leans forward.

JAMES
(ghostly through static)
Okay, you found the locked door. It whispers to you...

Behind him, THE LIGHTS FLICKER.

The camera jitters. Another teen SCREAMS.

The room TILTS sideways. The lens distorts.

One kid convulses violently. Another gasps for air.

PANIC erupts. Parents rush in—

The feed distorts, faces stretched, voices warped.

CUT TO BLACK.

INT. DEN - REALITY - PRESENT - SAME TIME

The group stands frozen.

The screen glows with STATIC.

A faint RED LIGHT blinks on the VCR: *REC.*

MAVERICK
(staggered, horrified)
They died here...

LUCAS
And it filmed itself.

They stand in silence.

The whirring tape recorder seems to breathe.

The house itself is recording.

INT. VOID ROOM - ALTERED REALITY

A table. Darkness pressing from every angle.

A single SPOTLIGHT isolates JAXTON. He looks hollowed out, barely standing.

Scattered before him: burned notes, torn maps, the melted remains of miniatures.

One CARD lies facedown. It PULSES, faint light bleeding beneath it.

Letters etch across its back: “THE FINAL MOVE: JAXTON WILLIS.”

His eyes blur with tears. He flips it.

CARD: “THE STORYTELLER.” A blank silhouette stares back.

Beneath it, scorched into the table: “START A STORY. REVEAL THE WOUND. PAY THE COST. ONLY THEN CAN YOU END IT.”

JAXTON
(choked)
It’s not a game. It’s a possession.

A voice coils through the void, too many tones in one.

PARASITIC VOICE (O.S.)
One must finish the story. One must remain. Choose. Surrender... or rewrite.

A second card forms beside it. Its back already smoking: “THE SACRIFICE.”

JAXTON
(soft)
I brought them here.
(beat)
And I’ll bring them home.

He lays his hand flat on the table.

The card IGNITES. A fire without heat, light without mercy. The table pulses red. The room begins to UNRAVEL.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
Then here’s the truth—
Stories don’t end because they finish.
(beat)
They end when we finally admit they were real. That they mattered.

The table SHUDDERS. Cards curl to ash. Dice combust to dust.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
That’s the cost, isn’t it?
Truth.

The final card flips one last time. A CRACK tears the room in two. The FEEDER SCREAMS somewhere beyond.

WHITE LIGHT CONSUMES JAXTON.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - MOMENTS LATER

The MAP RIPS in half. Dice EXPLODE. Wesley’s tablet glitches and DIES. The air drops twenty degrees.

Lucy, Maverick, and Lucas stare at the ruin. Silent. All hope lost.

Suddenly-

JAXTON STEPS OUT OF THE AIR.

Pale. Thinner. Eyes glowing faintly. But ALIVE.

LUCY
(soft)
Jax...?

JAXTON
There’s still one move left.

The TIMEPIECE TICKS. 9:13. Unstoppable.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
Someone stays. Or no one leaves.

A silence so heavy it could break bone.

MAVERICK
I’ll do it. I made the first roll.

LUCAS
No. It’s not after you.

LUCY
Stop.

She steps forward, trembling.

LUCY (CONT’D)
It let me in first. Chose me before any of this.

JAXTON
No, Lucy. You weren’t chosen to die.
(beat)
You were chosen to remember.

She shakes her head, devastated.

LUCY
I don’t want it.

JAXTON
That’s why it’s yours.
(beat)
You weren’t meant to survive. You were meant to carry it.

He moves to the center of the parlor. The table REBUILDS itself from ash. Cards rise again, dripping ink.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
I end it here.

LUCY
(tears streaming)
Jax, please don’t go...

Jaxton turns to each of them, broken but resolute.

He takes HOLLY’S empty chair in his hand, stroking it once. His voice cracks.

JAXTON
(to her absence)
You were the light I never deserved.

He pulls MAVERICK into a rough embrace.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
You were the brother I wanted to fight with forever. Keep laughing, Mav. Even when it hurts. Especially then.

Maverick crumbles.

He grips LUCAS by the shoulders, locking eyes.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
You saw me when no one else did. Don’t carry my silence, Lucas. Speak louder than I ever could.

Lucas BREAKS, sobbing, clinging to him.

Finally, Jaxton looks at LUCY. Everything in him is breaking.

JAXTON (CONT’D)
(to Lucy)
You gave me a world when ours ended. You kept me alive when Mom and Dad couldn’t. I love you, Luce. Always.

LUCY
Please... don’t make me lose you again.

He kisses her forehead. Pulls back. Tears streaming down both their faces.

JAXTON
My name is Jaxton Willis.
I started the story.
(beat)
And I’m ending it.

He turns to the air. His voice steady now, but soft—like prayer.

JAXTON (CONT'D)
I surrender.
I rewrite.
I stay.

The FEEDER SHRIEKS.

Jaxton is SWALLOWED by the light. Gone.

The LODGE goes SILENT.

INT/EXT. PARLOR - REALITY - DAWN

The front door CREAKS open. Lucy, Maverick, and Lucas step out into faint morning light. Their faces empty. Destroyed.

Behind them, the lodge is still. Dead.

A BLACK CROW perches on the gatepost. Watches. Then FLIES.

INT. PARLOR - CONTINUOUS

Empty. Ash and ruin.

A single MINIATURE tips over, Jaxton's NEON-BEARDED GOBLIN.

INT. CRAWLSPACE - BENEATH THE HOUSE - SAME TIME

Dark. A slow PULSING HUM. Like a heart too old to stop.

Blackened SHADOW ROOTS twitch in the soil. In their center: THE PARASITIC DEMON. THE FEEDER.

Its form is shifting, face always changing, eyes empty yet endless.

It PULSES in shades of BLACK, speaking in vibration.

PARASITIC DEMON (V.O.)
Another story told. Another door opened.
(beat)
Not yet free. But closer.

A root finds a crack. Reaches upward. Toward the palor.

INT. PARLOR - REALITY - LATER

The tablet screen FLICKERS. STILL STREAMING.

Text overlay: “LIVE · 1 viewer.”

CHAT: USER_0001 has entered the room.

A second line—glitched:

CHAT: Who’s next?

FAINT AUDIO: CHILD’S LAUGHTER.

A darkness seeping into the STREAM.

FADE TO BLACK.

INT. LUCY’S APARTMENT - NIGHT - WEEKS LATER

Lucy sits in silence. Her apartment dark. Funeral programs scattered on the table. Photos of Jaxton, Holly, Wesley, Kelly, Billy.

Candles half-melted. A framed photo: Jaxton at ten, bone D20 in hand. Lucy behind him.

LUCY (V.O.)
After our parents died, it was just me and Jax. I promised I’d take care of him.
(beat)
And I broke that promise.

She turns a notebook filled with SPIRALS.

Questions scrawled in frantic hand: “Who made the game?”, “Why me?”, “What’s the cost?”

LUCY (V.O.)
I can’t sleep. The spiral, it’s everywhere. It followed me out of the house.

She opens a drawer. Pulls out the CRACKED TIMEPIECE. Still ticking.

LUCY (V.O.)
Sometimes I hear him. Puck. Endings cost what truth won’t spare.

A whisper in the corners. The faint scrape of dice.

She flips to a page in her journal. Names. Dates. The spiral over and over.

LUCY (V.O.)
I thought it ended in that house.
But stories like this... they don't end. They echo.
(beat)
And I'm going to find out how.

She shuts the journal.

INSERT - THE TIMEPIECE ON THE TABLE.

9:13. TICK— 9:14. The ticking stops.

FADE TO BLACK.

TEXT ON SCREEN:

"SESSION TWO"

—COMING SOON—